



Lessons Learned
From a Fiery
Decade in L.A.

REVIEW

ROBERT KEBBECK

WSJ

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL WEEKEND



The Safari
Has Evolved

OFF DUTY

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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **The U.S. economy added 256,000 jobs in December** and the unemployment rate fell to 4.1%, a relief to households and businesses but a growing cause for concern in financial markets. **A1, A6**
- ◆ **The Dow fell 1.6%**, or almost 700 points while the S&P lost 1.5%, wiping out its 2025 gains, and the Nasdaq lost 1.6%, as the blockbuster jobs report made interest-rate cuts seem less likely. **B11**
- ◆ **Constellation Energy** agreed to buy Calpine for \$16.4 billion, combining two of the country's largest electricity generators. **B9**
- ◆ **Former WWE boss Vince McMahon** agreed to settle SEC charges that he failed to properly disclose payments he made over allegations of sexual misconduct. **B9**
- ◆ **Disney's ESPN**, Fox Corp. and Warner Bros. Discovery aren't moving forward with their joint streaming venture Venu Sports. **B9**
- ◆ **The European Commission** approved Synopsys' \$35 billion acquisition of Ansys. **B9**
- ◆ **Shares in Walgreens** surged 27% after a smaller-than-expected drop in adjusted earnings. **B10**
- ◆ **Hershey CEO Michele Buck**, the chocolate giant's leader since 2017, said she would step down in June 2026. **B10**

World-Wide

- ◆ **A defiant Donald Trump** was sentenced to no punishment for covering up hush money paid to a porn star, cementing his status as a felon on the cusp of his return to the White House. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump's real-estate company** is in talks to reclaim its former Washington, D.C., hotel, a move that could offer an early test of how he will handle potential conflicts of interest. **A1, A10**
- ◆ **Firefighters battling** devastating wildfires around Los Angeles hope a reprieve from powerful winds could help them contain the historic disaster that has so far scorched more than 35,000 acres and killed at least 11 people. **A1, A4-5**
- ◆ **The Supreme Court** voiced skepticism of TikTok's challenge to a federal law requiring the China-based social-media app to shut down or find new owners by Jan. 19. **A3**
- ◆ **A winter storm** in the South brought heavy snowfall, causing thousands of flight cancellations and several governors to declare states of emergency. **A3**
- ◆ **Venezuela's authoritarian leader Maduro** was sworn in for a third term after a July election he is widely seen as having lost in a landslide. **A7**
- ◆ **The Biden administration** tightened sanctions on the Russian energy sector. **A8**

NOONAN

Can Trump bring hope, and Biden wisdom? **A13**

CONTENTS	Markets & Fin.
Books.....	C7-12
Business & Fin. B9-10	Opinion.....
Design & Decor....	D9
Food.....	D7-8
Gear & Gadgets....	D6
Heard on Street....	B12
World News.....	A7-8



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Jobs Growth Tops Expectations

Report puts further
Fed rate cuts in
doubt; stocks sell
off, while yields rise

By PAUL KIERNAN

The U.S. labor market has found its footing, a relief to households and businesses but a growing cause for concern in financial markets. The U.S. economy added 256,000 jobs in December and

the unemployment rate edged down to 4.1%, the Labor Department said Friday. Last month's gain in nonfarm payrolls was the biggest since March, and well above the 155,000 jobs that economists had expected, according to a Wall Street Journal survey. The unemployment rate also was better than the expected 4.2%. Friday's jobs report was the latest sign that the U.S. labor market has recovered from its midyear stumble and might even be gaining steam. As such,

it shuts the door on an interest-rate cut at the Federal Reserve's next meeting, which is Jan. 28-29. It also reduces the chances of a cut at the Fed's subsequent meeting in March. "The labor market definitely cooled throughout 2024, and the concern was that it was cooling too fast," said Blerina Uruçi, chief U.S. economist at T. Rowe Price. "I don't think that concern is valid anymore." Stocks traded lower, a sign that investors are focused not on the strong U.S. economy

but on what the jobs report means for the Fed.

The Dow Jones Industrial Average, the S&P 500 and the Nasdaq Composite all fell 1.5% or more. The Dow gave up all the gains it has made since the presidential election.

The yield on the 10-year Treasury closed at 4.772%, up

- ◆ **Fed official says further cuts can wait.....** A6
- ◆ **Stocks slide, bond yields jump on jobs report.....** B11

U.S. 30-year Treasury bond



Source: Tullett Prebon



President-elect Donald Trump appeared virtually with lawyer Todd Blanche for his felony sentencing Friday in New York City.

Sentence Cements Trump As Felon

A defiant Donald Trump was sentenced in New York Friday to no punishment for covering up hush money paid to a porn star, sealing his status as a felon on the cusp of his return to the White House.

By Corinne Ramey,
James Fanelli
and Erin Mulvaney

Justice Juan Merchan, the presiding state court judge who handed down the sentence during a half-hour proceeding, said the extraordinary protections of the presidency insulated Trump from more substantial penalties.

"Donald Trump, the ordinary citizen, Donald Trump, the criminal defendant, would not be entitled to such considerable protections," Merchan told Trump.

But, the judge added, those protections "do not reduce the seriousness of the crime or justify its commission in any way."

Trump appeared virtually from his Mar-a-Lago residence in Florida, sitting with American flags behind him. He stared intently into his camera with his lips pursed and said he was innocent.

"It's been a political witch hunt," the president-elect said. "It was done to damage my reputation so I would lose the election."

The court hearing, which followed a conviction by a Manhattan jury in May, was unprecedented, making Trump not only the first former president to be found guilty of a

Please turn to page A2

CEOs Kill Policies Before Inauguration

Diversity, climate initiatives gutted

By ERICH SCHWARTZEL
AND CHIP CUTTER

Three years after Donald Trump left the White House, he published a coffee-table photobook of his first term that showed him meeting with Mark Zuckerberg in the Oval Office.

The photo carried an ominous warning. "We are watching him closely, and if he does anything illegal this time, he will spend the rest

of his life in prison," Trump said in the caption, accusing the Meta founder of steering Facebook against him during his 2020 re-election loss.

In recent days, Zuckerberg made moves seemingly intended for Trump to watch closely. Zuckerberg installed a veteran of the George W. Bush administration as his head of global policy, and he named Dana White—chief executive of Ultimate Fight-

Please turn to page A10

Trumps Begin Talks To Reclaim D.C. Hotel

By CRAIG KARMIN

Donald Trump's real-estate company is in talks to reclaim its former Washington, D.C., hotel, a move that could offer an early test of how the president-elect will handle potential conflicts of interest.

Eric Trump this week met at his family's Mar-a-Lago resort in Florida with an executive from merchant bank BDT & MSD Partners, which controls the long-term lease on the hotel, according to people familiar with the matter.

An executive vice president at the company, Eric Trump

discussed purchasing the lease, though the talks are still preliminary and may not lead to any sale, these people said.

The former Trump International Hotel in Washington, D.C., is now a Waldorf Astoria and operates in the Old Post Office building, which is owned by the federal government and was leased to the Trumps. Trump opened the hotel in 2016, but sold the lease rights in 2022 for \$375 million.

Now, the family firm is looking for a hotel in the capital as Trump prepares to return to the White House, and

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Lock-Kneed Soldiers Kick Up a Fuss

* * *
Taiwan veterans
fight to keep
goose-stepping

By JOYU WANG

TAIPEI, Taiwan—Once a month, under a highway overpass near military headquarters here, a small group of Taiwan army veterans band together in a coordinated act of defiance.

Lined up in a row, wooden dummy rifles on their shoulders, they move slowly in unison in a goose step, the now-taboo lock-kneed marching style their army adopted on the Chinese mainland nearly 100 years ago.

In their youth, the goose-steppers of Taiwan weren't cooped up. For much of the history of the Republic of

Please turn to page A8

Weaker Winds Provide Hope in Wildfire Fight

LOS ANGELES—Firefighters battling wildfires around Los Angeles hope a reprieve from powerful winds this weekend could help them contain a disaster that has scorched more than 35,000 acres and killed at least 11 people.

By Jennifer Calfas,
Garth Vipers and
Sara Randazzo

President Biden told reporters Friday that the death toll would likely increase.

"Whether it's significantly or not, we don't know yet," Biden said. "There are still a lot of people who are unaccounted for. We don't know where they are."

The dayslong battle against at least five wildfires burning across the area has Los Angeles residents on edge. New fires seem to spark daily, prompting additional evacuation orders and worries more homes could be lost.

Additional evacuation orders were issued and then lifted Friday after firefighters quickly stopped the growth of a 31.5-acre brush fire near the city's Granada Hills neighborhood.

At least 10,000 homes, businesses and other structures have been destroyed. More than 150,000 residents have been forced to leave their homes, and 166,000 others are under evacuation warnings.

The two largest wildfires—one that burned through the Pacific Palisades neighborhood, and another that devastated Altadena and Pasadena—were considered among the five most destructive in state history, according to preliminary data from the state's Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, or Cal Fire.

Please turn to page A4

- ◆ **One wildfire swept away a middle-class paradise.....** A4
- ◆ **Disasters raise insurance rates, even far away.....** A4



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